



“Founders mitigate this (data sharing) risk by patent-first engineering and defensive publications before pilots. They file Indian patents through TIFAC-KIRAN or incubator support, followed by PCT (Patent Cooperation Treaty) if needed”

BHASKAR MAJUMDAR
MANAGING PARTNER, UNICORN INDIA VENTURES



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ASHISH TANEJA
FOUNDER & CEO, GROWX VENTURES

paying customers), the path becomes much clearer. At this point, it is much easier to make allocation and prioritisation decisions based on likely revenue projections rather than some unproven valuation metric,” says Bruce Keith, co-founder and CEO of InvestorAi, a personal AI investment analyst.

According to Venture Catalysts, start-ups with at least 24 months of runway see nearly 2x pilot-to-revenue conversion. But making pilots work is not an easy task either.

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CHALLENGES TO PILOTS

Pilots often prove technical feasibility but not commercial readiness. Enterprises care about integration, reliability, RoI, and long-term support, and not just whether the technology works. “Start-ups that succeed here design pilots with scale in mind from day one. Importantly, they treat pilots as sales processes, not experiments, using them to lock in budgets, timelines, and expansion pathways upfront,” says Ashish Taneja, Founder & CEO, growX Ventures.

Another big challenge in AI pilots is enabling real-world testing without exposing sensitive data or intellectual property. The AI data privacy challenge is acute in India’s healthcare (patient data), fintech (compliance), and manufacturing (IoT risks). Open experimentation creates risk, while overly restricted pilots produce meaningless results.

The most effective solution is secure, sandboxed environments using masked or synthetic datasets that replicate statistical behaviour. Funding can come from government AI missions, venture capital firms, big tech investments, and bootstrapped start-ups.

“Time-bound pilots tied to measurable outcomes, and not open-ended experimentation, will allow firms to move quickly while remaining compliant.